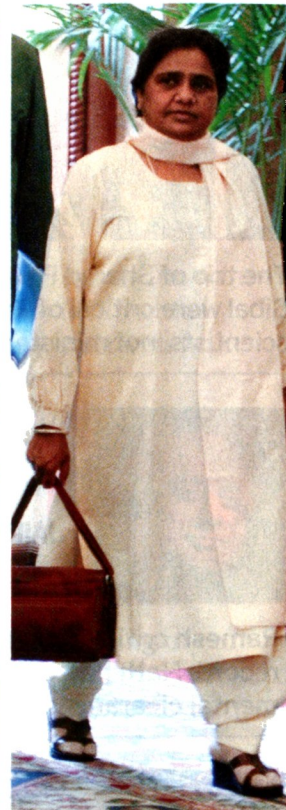
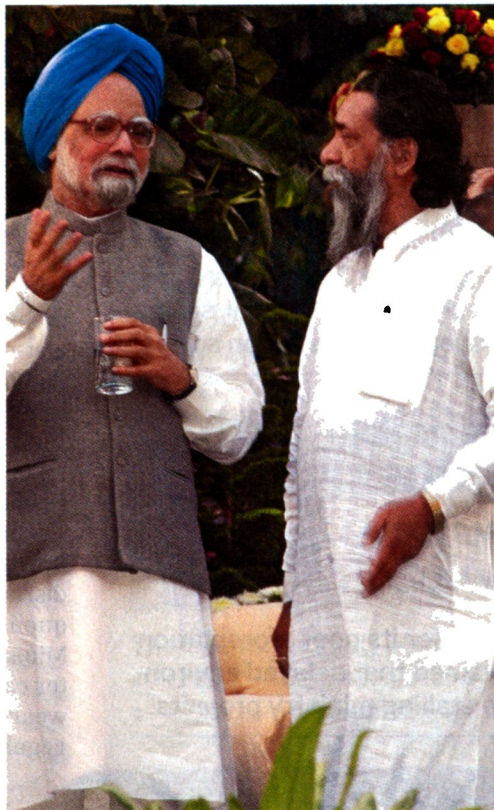


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(FROM LEFT) THE YADAV DUO, MANMOHAN WITH SHIBU SOREN, MAYAWATI

The War Within and OUTSOURCING DISSENT

Handling sulking allies is a part-time issue. Manmohan's crisis managers have a full-time occupation separating warring leaders. The most illustrative example is the salvo fired by party general secretary Digvijay Singh who described Chidambaram as "intellectually arrogant" and questioned the policy on tackling Maoists. His suggestion for a development-oriented approach was not new but the public forum of a newspaper column that he used suggested all was not well within the Congress. To aggravate matters, newly nominated member of the Rajya Sabha Mani Shankar Aiyar agreed with Singh in rather graphic terms, "one lakh per cent" as he described it. The fact that he was taking on Chidambaram, an old bete noir only added grist to the gossip mill in and outside the party. Speaking in Parliament, Chidambaram urged his colleagues to dump 'romantic notions about Naxalites'. Naturally, the BJP seized upon the opportunity to declare a civil war within the UPA.

Some in the Congress believe the call received by Digvijay from Sonia was a signal for rebels with or without a cause to refrain. But there could be trouble ahead, with the outsourcing of dissent in the revival of the

National Advisory Council (NAC). The joke at Raisina Hill is that it is Government versus Sonia's NGOs. The Congress chief often turns to activists for political course correction and for drafting policy whether it is the NREGA, RTI or more recently, the Food Security Bill. Take the last. The Congress promised 25 kg of grain at Rs 3 per kg in its manifesto. The draft bill offered 25 kg but it was seen to be less than the 35 kg offered by the A.B. Vajpayee regime under the Antyodaya scheme. The bill is being redrafted and will cost Rs 30,000 crore more in food subsidy. Citing an already high deficit, the Finance Ministry has refused to pay up. As always, caught in the tussle between the party and Government is the prime minister.

Many fear that the NAC, aimed to bridge the political gap between the party and the Government, may actually widen it. That may not be necessarily true. It was the NAC that delivered the winning idea of NREGA and empowerment through the RTI. What the Congress needs badly is new ideas. If the NAC is able to guide the priorities of the Government, it may win back the higher moral ground and public support. The government needs to get its bearings back. If it doesn't, regardless of well laid plans, it could find itself knocked off the perch by what Mukherjee so eloquently described as "accidents that count".

with inputs from Shafi Rahman, Subhash Mishra and Amitabh Srivastava